Singulari quadam

Pius X · 1912-09-24 · English

THE LETTER

To Our Beloved Son, George Cardinal Kopp, Bishop of Breslau, and to Our Venerable Brothers, the other Archbishops and Bishops of Germany — Pius PP.X.

Beloved Son and Venerable Brothers, Health and the Apostolic Benediction :

{SinguLari quadam). Our special love and good will towards the Catholics of Germany, who are united to the Apostolic See by ties of closest allegiance and obedience, and who have al- ways fought generously and strenuously for the Church, have impelled Us, Venerable Brothers, to devote all Our attention and care to the settlement of the controversy which exists among them concerning labor unions. It is a question that has fre- quently been brought to Our notice during recent years by several of yourselves and by prudent and sensible men belong- ing to both parties. We have devoted Ourselves all the more earnestly to this matter inasmuch as the sense of Our Apostolic office makes Us feel that it is Our sacred duty to strive and to ensure that these beloved children of Ours keep the Catholic doctrine unadulterated and entire, and on no account allow their faith to be endangered. For there is evident danger that if they are not promptly stimulated to be on their guard they may gradually and, as it were, unconsciously, settle down into that species of vague and indefinite Christianity, known as " Interconfessionalism," which is now being diffused on the false plea of a common Christian faith, whereas nothing could be more clearly opposed to the preaching of Jesus Christ. More- over, as it is Our most ardent desire to foster and consolidate harmony among Catholics, we wish to see every possible cause removed which can breed those dissensions that divide the energies of the good, and serve only the interests of the enemies of religion. So too We desire that, together with their fellow- countrymen who do not profess the Catholic faith, they culti- vate that peace without which neither social order nor national prosperity can exist.

ASKED FOK OPINIONS

But although, as We have said, We understood the state of this question. We have been pleased, before deciding it, to ask each of you. Venerable Brothers, for his opinion, and you at Our request have individually answered with the diligence and care that the importance of the matter called for.

In the first place, we therefore insist that it is the duty of all Catholics, a duty to be faithfully and inviolately observed both in private and in common and public life, to hold firmly and to profess unshrinkingly the principles of Christian truth en- trusted to the teaching authority of the Catholic Church. We refer especially to those principles set forth most advisedly by Our Predecessor in the encyclical Rerum novarum, which, as We know, the Bishops of Prussia, who met at Pulda in 1900, closely followed in their deliberations, and which We realize you yourselves have also had in mind in writing back to Us your opinion on this question. To wit :

That whatever a Christian may do, even in the order of earthly things, he is never permitted to disregard the good that is above nature, but according to the dictates of Chris- tian wisdom must look to the supreme good as to his ulti- mate end; and that all his actions, in as far as they are good or bad in the order of morals, — i.e. in as far as they are in harmony or in conflict with the natural and Divine law — come under the judgment and jurisdiction of the Church.

That all who, as individuals or as members of an organiza- tion, glory in the Christian name should be mindful of their duty to promote among the classes of society not enmities and hidden grudges, but mutual peace and charity.

That the social question and the controversies connected with it regarding the conditions and hours of labor, salaries or strikes, are not of a purely economic character and therefore not of a kind that can be settled without reference to the au- thority of the Church, " since on the contrary, it is altogether true that [the social question] is first of all a moral and reli- gious one, and therefore to be settled mainly by the moral law and the judgment of religion." *

6 Encyclical Graves de Communi.

workinqmen's societies

Now, with reference to workinginen's societies, although their object is to secure temporal advantages for their members, those are to be regarded as worthy of the highest approval, and as the best fitted to promote the real and solid utility of their members, which are founded chiefly on the basis of the Catholic religion and openly follow the leadership of the Church. This We have Ourselves several times declared for different nations, as occasion offered.

Hence it follows that such Catholic as- sociations should be established and favored in every way, certainly in Catholic countries and in all other places also where it appears that through them provision can be made for the various needs of their members. In the case of associations which directly or indirectly touch the cause of religion or morals, We cannot in any way approve the attempt to promote or propagate mixed associations, that is, those which are made up of Catholics and non-Catholics, in the countries just men- tioned. For, to say nothing of other reasons, the integrity of the faith of Our own people and their just respect for the laws and precepts of the Church are, or certainly may be, greatly endangered through such societies. Of the existence of these dangers We find an open acknowledgment, Venerable Brothers, in many of your answers on this question.

THE CARTEL.

Hence We gladly bestow all praise on the purely Catholic workingmen's associations in Germany, and We wish them suc- cess in all their efforts to promote the welfare of the toiling multitudes, and hope they will develop ever more and more happily. But in saying this We do not deny that, to better the state of the worker, and his wages, the conditions of labor, or for any other honest and useful purpose, it is lawful for Catholics to work in common with non-Catholics for the com- mon welfare, provided the proper precaution is taken. But We prefer that in doing this, Catholic societies and non-Catholic societies be united in that kind of happily devised understand- ing known as the Cartel.

CHBISTIAN SYNDICATE'S

But here, Venerable Brothers, many of you ask Us that you be permitted by Us to tolerate what are known as the Chris- tian Syndicates [i.e. Christian Trade Unions],'^ as they exist at present in your dioceses, on the ground that the number of workingmen they contain is far greater than that of the purely Catholic associations and that grave inconveniences would fol- low if such permission were withheld. This petition We think well to grant in view of the special conditions of Catholicism in Germany, and We declare that it is tolerated and permitted for Catholics to join these mixed societies which exist in your dioceses, as long as new circumstances do not make this tolerance inopportune and unjust. This, however, We grant on condi- tion [ita tamen] that suitable precautions be taken to obviate those dangers which, as We have said, are to be found in such organizations. The chief of these precautions are as follows: First of all, care is to be taken that the Catholic workers who are members of those syndicates be enrolled also in those Cath- olic societies for workingmen which are called Workingmen's Associations [Arheitervereine], Should this entail some sacri- fice to them, especially of money, we take it for certain that, eager as they are for the preservation of their faith, they will willingly make it. For experience happily shows that these Catholic associations, thanks to the clergy under whose leader- ship and vigilance they are conducted, contribute greatly to- wards preserving the purity of the faith and the good moral conduct of their members and towards fostering their religious spirit by various pious exercises. Thus there can be no doubt that the leaders of these associations, with their knowledge of present conditions, will communicate to the workingmen those precepts and prescriptions which they kn6w to be necessary or useful for them, so that they may properly be members of the s^mdicates and live according to the principles of Catholic teaching.

1 Christliche Oewerkschaften.

DUTIES OF BISHOPS

Moreover, these syndicates, to be fit for Catholic members, must refrain from all methods and acts out of harmony with the doctrines and commands of the Church or of legitimate sacred authority, and their writings, utterances or doings must in this respect contain nothing reprehensible. Hence the Bishops are to consider it a most sacred duty, to observe carefully how these societies are conducted and to see that Catholics take no harm from intercourse with them. And the Catholic members of these syndicates in their own turn, must never permit the syndicates, even as such, while looking after the earthly advantages of their members, to profess or do things in anyways contrary to the precepts entrusted to the supreme teaching authority of the Church, and especially to those maxims we have mentioned above. To this end, whenever ques- tions arise affecting moral topics, that is, of justice or charity, the Bishops shall watch most carefully that the faithful do not disregard the Catholic code of morals or depart so much as a hair's breadth from its observance.

We are, indeed, certain. Venerable Brothers, that you will eee that these prescriptions of Ours are religiously and in- violately observed, and that you will diligently and assiduously keep Us informed on a matter of such moment. Since We have taken this question upon Ourselves, We reserve to Ourselves all decisions concerning it. With the advice of the Bishops, we enjoin upon all good Catholics to abstain hereafter from all controversy among themselves on the subject. We are pleased to believe that, observing fraternal charity and showing entire obedience to Our

authority and that of their pastors, they will carry out fully and heartily what We order. Should any difficulty arise they have a ready means for settling it: let them approach their Bishops and lay the matter before them and let the latter submit the question to this Apostolic See, which will decide it.

PEACE AITD PROGRESS

We need but add, as indeed is clear from what We have said, that no Catholics who are constant in their defense of the teach- ings and rights of the Church, and who, with a proper inten- tion, wish to be or are members of the mixed syndicates in places where the religious authority has seen fit to permit membership in them because of local conditions, shall be attacked or accused as suspect in the Faith, — understanding that all necessary precautions are taken. So, too, it would be highly reprehensible to pursue with hostility the purely Catholic as- sociations — which indeed are to be helped and promoted in every way, and to try to introduce and, as it were, to impose the interconfessional trade unions, on the pretext, among other reasons, of reducing all the societies of Catholics in the various dioceses to one and the same form.

Meanwhile, in Our desire that Catholic Germany may enjoy great progress, both religious and civil, "We implore for this happy end the special assistance of Almighty God and the protection of the Virgin Mother of God, who is the Queen of Peace, and as an augury of Divine gifts and a pledge of Our special affection. We most lovingly impart the Apostolic Benediction to you, Beloved Son and Venerable Brothers, and to your clergy and people.

Given at Rome at St. Peter's, September 24th, 1912, in the tenth year of Our Pontificate.

PIUS, PP. X.

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